



surface is made from bright steel

closed visor protects face, but limits field of view

single pivot for visor and face guard

peg for lifting visor

upper bevor decorated with figures in Roman armor

neck guard

breastplate is combined with a neck guard

separate plates offer protection, but allow movement



The return of armor
During World War I, body armor was revived. German machine gunners wore suits like this one when firing from exposed places.

77 lb THE APPROXIMATE WEIGHT OF A FULL SUIT OF EUROPEAN 16TH-CENTURY TOURNAMENT ARMOR

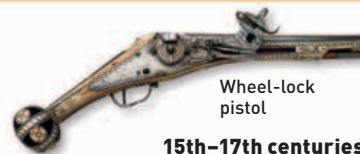


Chain mail

11th century
Mail perfected
Lighter and less bulky than armor plate, chain mail worn over a gambeson (padded jacket) saves lives.

1100 onward
Swords improve
The cross-guard is added to protect the hand, and marks the first big change to sword design since Roman times. Refined edges mean swords can now cut and stab.

15th century
First suits of full plate armor develop
Suits of armor provide the best protection. Gloves now have jointed fingers, while shoulder plates bring freer movement and less exposure.



Wheel-lock pistol

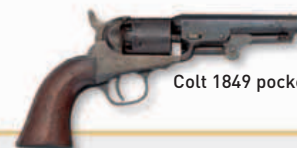
15th–17th centuries
Firearms developed
With the invention of guns, body armor shrinks back to the cuirass (breastplate), to allow for drawing of pistols.



Reinforced flak jacket

1939–1945
Flak jackets
Based on the same design as the cuirass, World War II flak jackets stop shrapnel, but not bullets.

19th century
Automatic-loading firearms
The advent of the revolver, with its rotating cylinder, meant that multiple shots could be fired before reloading.



Colt 1849 pocket pistol

20th–21st centuries
Kevlar and “liquid” body armor
Kevlar threads are five times stronger than steel. Soaked in shear thickening fluid (STF), it can withstand bullet penetration.